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• Editorial Office Living Media India Ltd. F-1475, Connaught Place New Delhi 110001. Phones: 23315801-4;

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Phones: Toll-free number: 1800 1800 100 (from BSNL/MTNL lines); (95120) 2479900 from Delhi and

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General Manager (Sales), Living Media India Limited, 201 Competent House, F-14, Middle Circle, Connaught Place,

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Kamala City, Senapati Bapat Marg, Lower Parel, Mumbai 400001 • Phone: 23327330 • 98-A, Dr. Radhakrishnan Salai,

House, 1-A, Connaught Place, New Delhi 110001 • Phone: 23352233; Fax: 041-6177 Into In: Fax: 28472178; Cable:

2nd Floor, Mylapore, Chennai-600 004; Phones: 28478526-41; Telex: 041-6177 Into In: Fax: 28472178; Cable:

Livmedia Chennai • 201-204 Richmond Towers, 2nd Floor, 12, Richmond Road, Bangalore-560025; Phones:

22212448, 22213037, 22218343; Fax: 22218335; Cable: Livmedia, Bangalore • 52, Jawaharlal Nehru Road,

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• 24C, "Suryarath Rldg", 2nd Floor, Behind White House, Panchwati, Office C.G. Road, Ahmedabad-380006;

Phone: 26560193, 26560129; Fax: 26565293

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In its short but very significant seven years, the INDIA TODAY Conclave has always kept its pact with history. Each successive Conclave has grappled with issues central to India's growth in these early years of the 21st century. The first Conclave, held in the aftermath of 9/11 centred around the theme of 'India Tomorrow: Opportunities and Threats'. Successive events have looked at issues like bridging the divide between the two Indias or building an Indian century.

Last year the Conclave went global in its scope with the theme 'The Brave New World'. This year's theme was a logical progression: 'Leadership for the 21st century'. For this we invited leaders from within India and across the world, to share their ideas and vision.

They included 42nd US President Bill Clinton who opened the Conclave with a live two-way satellite address in which he said that "removing inequality and insecurity" should be the key agendas for those who guided the destinies of countries or corporations. Quite fittingly, his vice-president, Al Gore, Nobel prize winner and eco warrior, delivered the concluding keynote address exhorting India to take the moral lead in tackling the critical issues of climate change and global warming.

In between, industrialists, scientists, politicians, moviemakers, spiritual gurus and sportsmen gave us their views on what it takes to lead and succeed at the very top. Mukesh Ambani predicted that the coming century was going to be dominated by the emerging economies but warned that only enlightened businesses could address the source of world turmoil—poverty.

One of the world's most celebrated biologists Dr J. Craig Venter talked about how the development of synthetic biology could have dramatic consequences on medicine and the search for alternative energy sources.

As the speakers gave us their opinions, some of them were also happy to make news, maintaining an established Conclave tradition. BJP stalwart L.K. Advani took a potshot at the Congress stating that his party had "no reservations" when it came to issues of leadership. Digvijay Singh and Narendra Modi got into a heated debate over votebank politics, with the political panel admitting that the cynical practice existed and it would be long before it disappeared. Movie star Aamir Khan accused corporations of failing to understand the creative process. Australian cricketer Adam Gilchrist tried to calm the troubled waters between India and Australia but admitted he was "no saint" when it came to on-field verbal jousting.

There were many memorable moments at this year's gathering and once again, the Conclave proved to be an arena of intellects and a hothouse of arguments. We have condensed them for you in this issue. I hope the discussions will enrich your world of ideas as much as they did ours and leave you with the same feeling of optimism as I had in spite of the enormous challenges ahead.

Aroon Purie
(Aroon Purie)